Marco Lo Faso

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USC Dornsife
Dana and David Dornsife
College of Letters, Arts and Sciences
Department of Economics

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Placement Director: Vittorio Bassi, vbassi@usc.edu
Placement Director: Michael Droste, droste@usc.edu
Placement Administrator: Annie Le, anniele@usc.edu

Education

University of Southern California
Ph.D. Economics (expected) 2027
Harvard University
Visiting Ph.D. Student, Department of Economics 2025–2026
Bocconi University
M.Sc. Public Policy and Political Economy 2019
B.Sc. Economics 2016

Fields

Political Economy, Spatial Economics, Applied Microeconomics

References

Thomas Chaney (Chair)	Augustin Bergeron	Jeff Weaver
USC Economics	Harvard Economics	USC Economics
thomas.chaney@usc.edu	abergeron@fas.harvard.edu	jbweaver@usc.edu

Job Market Paper

The Geography of Protests: Spatial Fragmentation, Exposure, and Participation in the George Floyd Movement

Whether protest movements win votes for their cause or cost them votes is unsettled. This paper studies the question by treating protests as spatial events. I ask whether residents of neighborhoods near protest sites, who are exposed to a protest, react differently when they vote from those of neighborhoods where participants come from. Combining 7,920 geocoded George Floyd protest events with mobile phone location data, I measure protest participation from each block group. I then exploit differences in exposure and participation within the same zip code to estimate the effect of each on the change in vote shares between 2016 and 2020. Neighborhoods near protest sites saw increases in Republican vote share, a backlash that decays with distance and is larger near violent protests. Neighborhoods whose residents attended protests saw increased Democratic vote share. The effects coexist: the backlash is large but concentrated in a few neighborhoods, the mobilization small but spread across many neighborhoods. Participation moved about 137,000 votes toward the Democrats, while exposure near protest sites cost them about 87,000; the net is not distinguishable from zero. On these estimates, violence cost the movement about half of its potential local gains. The protests' direct local effects are unlikely to have decided the 2020 election.

Work in Progress

Congregations and the Market for Urban Floor Space: Evidence from São Paulo
The Urban Constraints on Political Mobilization: Evidence from American Cities
The Labor Market Returns to Religious Networks: Evidence from Uganda (with Aruj Shukla)

Awards

Dean's Dissertation Completion Fellowship, USC — $21,218 2026–2027
Lusk Center for Real Estate Research Award, USC — $13,500 2026
Lusk Center for Real Estate Research Award, USC — $15,000 2025
Dan James Fellowship, USC — $40,000 2024–2025
Summer Research Award (x4), USC — $4,000 each 2023–2026

Employment

European Central Bank, Frankfurt, Research Intern 2019
European Commission, Brussels, Economic Analyst 2017–2018

Research Positions

Research Assistant to Augustin Bergeron, USC 2023
Research Assistant to Ruben Durante, Pompeu Fabra University 2020–2021
Research Assistant to Vincenzo Galasso, Bocconi University 2019–2020

Teaching

Teaching Assistant, University of Southern California Fall 2022–Spring 2024
Introduction to Econometrics (ECON 318), undergraduate
Political Economy and Economic Development (ECON 436), undergraduate
Intermediate Macroeconomics (ECON 305), undergraduate
Macroeconomic Analysis and Policy (ECON 501), master
Teaching Assistant, Bocconi University 2019–2020
Welfare and Politics, master
Economics of European Integration, master
Political Economics, undergraduate
European Economic Policy, undergraduate

Presentations

2026: USC Development Seminar, Harvard Graduate Student Workshop in Political Economy
2023–2026: USC Applied Micro Reading Group

Summer Schools

Summer School in the Economics of Migration, UC Davis 2024
ACES Summer School in Political Economy, UC Berkeley 2023

Academic Service

Co-organizer, Southern California Graduate Conference in Applied Economics
University of Southern California 2023

Research Grants

Weiss Fund Research Grant — $5,000 2023–2024

Software Skills

Python, R, Stata, MATLAB

Languages

Italian (native), English (fluent)

Citizenship

Italian (US F-1 visa)